she finds relief, peace and joy in her explorations.

At the heart of the Vedantic inquiry lie the questions 'who am I' and 'what is reality'. The answer, as her book shows with tremendous honesty, beauty, poignance and joy, is simple ("you are that") but also dependent on the nature of the individual receiving the teaching. Namita gets palpable sustenance from her ever-increasing sense of the interconnectedness of everything, the relaxing of the ego, the contentment of being part of a larger whole. The book is full of music, stories and experiences that indicate the deepening of her realisation. She "moults" into surrender—"a long exhalation after years of short, hurried breaths." In the end, nothing we can point to changes, yet everything does. ■

—Juhi Saklani

by Rudrangshu Mukherjee). Davidar feels the impressive line-up of authors "should help the books find a readership".

Subsequent volumes will continue to provide concise and insightful introductions to quintessential aspects of India. These include books on small-town India (by Ruskin Bond), the lotus (by Devdutt Pattanaik), Hinduism (by Rajmohan Gandhi), the monsoon (by Stephen Alter), the mango (by Sona Bahadur), and so on. The plan, says Davidar, is "to publish 5-10 books every year over the next 4-5 years and get to about 50 books or so by the time the series is complete. Around half the books have already been commissioned and we will hope to have the entire series commissioned by the end of the year." ■

—Amit Dixit

When a Hindu Dies in SAN FRANCISCO

A DARKLY FUNNY TALE OF DEATH, FAMILY, AND CULTURAL COLLISION, *EVERY ROOM HAS A VIEW* TURNS A SILICON VALLEY CREMATION INTO A SITCOM-LIKE SPECTACLE

Naveen Gupta's body lies on a dining table, pushed against a bay window facing the Golden Gate and Alcatraz. Naveen, an engineer who made good in the Silicon Valley boom of the 1990s, has left behind a will, asking to be cremated in San Francisco "on a pyre on the shore", with the same ceremonies as he'd cremated his father 30 years ago: "Whatever I may have been in life, let me be a Hindu in death."



EVERY ROOM HAS A VIEW
By Sujit Saraf
SPEAKING TIGER
₹499; 256 pages

A vividly visual, upside-down comedy of manners, *Every Room Has a View* at times reads like a sitcom about death

Surrounding him is his family: his wife, Usha, who studies his profile, "Death gives to one's face a refinement not seen in life"; his teenage son, Ajay, who can sing the Ahir Bhairav with ease and is about to go to Carnegie Mellon; his mother, Maaji, who keeps muttering, "*Abhi mara nahin hai, abhi mar raha hai*"; and Jeff, Naveen's Jewish-Republican legal executor.

As the story progresses, we meet a jeans-clad pandit with a backpack; a young cow who's brought up the elevator; the barber arrives from Supercuts and the ice-packs from Costco; cops on the beach mistake the pyre for a campfire.

The India flashbacks flicker with cliché: matrimonials of 'homely' girls with 'wheatish' complexion doing 'Home Science'; Navneet's brother has a shop in Meerut, we're not told what kind—pretty generic, but there's a keen observation about wheatish Usha, "By marrying into America, she'd leap-frogged the (Indian) color pyramid."

Set in the forty eight hours after Naveen's death, the novel is a double-decker bus of two cultures, a sort of upside-down comedy of manners and so vividly visual, at times it's like watching a sitcom about death, with lashings of *Seinfeld*-like humour: "There was no dramatic departure...dials flickered and went to zero, meters registered heartbeats that faded away.... It did not look like death but the termination of a science experiment."

—Palash Krishna Mehrotra